

TUNA PACKS

Tuna travel in schools that mount concerted attacks on smaller schooling fish. They are fast, powerful hunters, reaching speeds of up to 47 mph (75 kph). Some can grow to amazing sizes—the Atlantic bluefin tuna can reach 15 ft (4.6 m). But overfishing has made some species rare, and the Atlantic bluefin may be threatened with extinction.

Oceanic hunters

Schooling fish are hunted by bigger fish. Some of these also swim in schools, but others live alone. They include tuna, which hunt in packs, and sharp-snouted billfish. These oceanic hunters are fast enough to outrun a powerful speedboat. They owe their speed to their streamlined bodies, powerful muscles, and incredibly efficient ways of generating energy. They are among the most specialized hunters on the planet.

WOW!

The sailfish is the fastest fish in the sea—one was timed at an astonishing 68 mph (110 kph) as it streaked in to attack.



SLEEK AND SPEEDY

Tuna can swim incredibly fast because of a combination of special adaptations. Not only are they super-streamlined, their huge flank muscles drive their crescent-shaped tail fin from side to side at such high speed that it almost acts like the propeller of a powerboat. The faster they swim, the faster the water flows through their gills, and this provides extra oxygen to turn blood sugar into energy. These fish can also raise their body temperatures to well above the temperature of the water, making their muscles even more efficient.

